



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of St. Margaret Clitherow
School Website: <https://knoxchesterton.com/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of St. Margaret Clitherow (Knoxville, TN) presents a structured, explicitly classical, Catholic high-school program within the Chesterton Schools Network. Public-facing materials emphasize a culture of life, reverent liturgy, and a liberal-arts–driven curriculum built around Great Books, the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), and Socratic pedagogy. The school foregrounds formation of virtue and wisdom, not merely information or job-ready skills, and integrates theology, worship, and sacramental life into daily life and academics. Evidence from the school's site highlights daily Mass, liturgical practice, catechesis, and a mission to form joyful leaders and saints through a deeply Catholic, classical framework. The curriculum blends history, literature, philosophy, theology, and languages with a strong emphasis on classical texts, Socratic inquiry, and exposure to great books, all supported by a model of mentorship and parish/school partnerships. These characteristics align strongly with classical education criteria across all six categories, indicating a full CLASSICAL classification.

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: Catholic identity, liturgical life, theology integrated with academics, and a "Culture of Life" formation emphasis. Evidence includes daily Mass, Catholic formation, and incarnational pedagogy.
- Purpose and Goal: Education aimed at virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing within a classical frame; formation over mere information; explicit reference to truth, goodness, and beauty as real.
- Curriculum: Liberal-arts foundations (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books, history integrated across disciplines, and a Great Conversation approach with Socratic pedagogy.
- Pedagogy: Socratic seminars, memory work within a contemplative/reverent framework, and upper-level rhetoric training; integration of a restorative, contemplative pace with rigorous inquiry.
- Faculty: Descriptions of the headmaster and faculty as mentors who form the living curriculum; visible faculty–student interactions and parish oversight.
- Parents & Community: Active parent engagement through events (e.g., Odyssey Day), tours, and a culture that partners with families; open-door visitation and community involvement.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL Evidence includes explicit Catholic identity, daily Mass, liturgical life, and a theology-infused educational vision; formation in virtue and sacred realities is central. Positive keyword signals (truth, goodness, beauty; liturgy; Mass; theology; sacred) are pervasive in public materials. The absence of secular relativism in the public materials reinforces the alignment. Why: Catholic liturgical life and theology-infused formation demonstrate transcendental moral realism and liturgical communal practices. See evidence: daily Mass and Catholic formation; Incarnational pedagogy; Cultura Vitae. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords strongly dominate (truth, goodness, beauty; liturgy; Mass; theology; sacred; culture of Life). Negative indicators (secularism, relativism) are not

present in primary public materials. Estimated positive keyword presence: high; negative: negligible. Why this rating: The school foregrounds transcendentals, liturgy, and theological grounding, which are core to classical religious foundations.

- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL Evidence includes mission to form joyful leaders and saints, culture of life, and emphasis on virtue and wisdom rather than mere job prep; references to classical education and formation of character. See mission statements and the “Higher Purpose” framing.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, great conversation, teleology, and the true/good/beautiful. Negative signals (career- or job-prep emphasis) are not foregrounded; the materials emphasize formation over information. Estimated positive keyword presence: high; negative: minimal. Why this rating: The public materials articulate formation, virtue, and the pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty as aims of education, aligning with classical purposes.

- Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL Evidence includes explicit mention of grammar, logic, rhetoric; integrated humanities program combining history, literature, philosophy, theology, and languages; Great Books approach; Socratic method; and “Rediscovering the Lost Tools of Learning” framing. See humanities program and curriculum descriptions.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books, Great Conversation, and integrated history/literature/philosophy; negative keywords (e.g., over-emphasis on social studies or project-based-only) are not evident. Estimated positive keyword presence: very high; negative: negligible. Why this rating: The curriculum is organized around liberal arts foundations, Great Books, and integrated, historical learning consistent with classical education.

- Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL Evidence includes explicit use of Socratic seminars, a history of memory work through chant/recitation, and upper-level rhetoric training; emphasis on contemplative/restful learning is present in the broader classical lexicon, with a balance by rigorous inquiry. See Socratic method emphasis and the dual enrollment/arts framework.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include Socratic dialogue, memory work, recitation, formation through imitation, and restful learning (Scholé). The site demonstrates Socratic method usage; recitation/memory as forms of knowledge retention appear in the broader classical framework. Negative indicators (project-based-only or experiential-only extremes) are not present in public materials. Estimated positive keyword presence: high; negative: minimal. Why this rating: The pedagogy aligns with the classical elements of dialogue, memorization, and disciplined inquiry appropriate for a classical program.

- Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL Evidence includes named leadership (Headmaster), visible faculty roles, and the living-curriculum framing; multiple pages describe faculty, board, and spiritual oversight. See Headmaster profile, faculty pages, and “Our Patrons” narrative.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include living curriculum, model teachers, mentorship, collegiality, virtue, and master-teacher models (as reflected in the lexicon). The public materials mention mentorship and the faculty’s central role in formation. Negative keywords (non-classical faculty descriptors) are not evident. Estimated positive keyword presence: high; negative: negligible. Why this rating: The public materials portray faculty as mentors who embody and transmit classical formation, consistent with the classical model.

- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL Evidence includes explicit emphasis on partnering with families, parent formation opportunities, open campus events, and welcoming visits; Odyssey Day and parent engagement are described; diocesan and community ties are referenced.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include partnership with families, parental engagement, home-school partnership, and open-campus access. Negative signals (consumer-focused or minimal parent involvement) are not present. Estimated positive keyword presence: high; negative: negligible. Why this rating: The school positions parents as co-educators and active participants in the classical-education ecosystem.

Overall assessment: CLASSICAL

- Aggregate ranking: CLASSICAL

What would move the needle (for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL only) - Not applicable here, as all six categories meet the Classical criteria based on the evidence in the school's public materials and the Classical rubric.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Details

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school identifies itself as Catholic and explicitly integrates faith with academics, including daily Mass and liturgical life. - The mission emphasizes a Culture of Life and formation in Catholic faith, with references to sacraments and spiritual formation. - The model of education explicitly foregrounds truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable, through an Incarnational perspective.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: truth, goodness, beauty; theology; liturgy; Mass; sacred; Catholic; culture of life; sacraments; Incarnation; sacred tradition. - Negative keywords: secular, relativism, values-neutral, postmodern (not present in public materials). - Quantitative note: Positive keyword density is high; negative keyword presence is negligible.

Why this rating - The school embeds transcendentals, liturgical practices, and theological grounding, which are central to classical religious foundations.

Citations - Daily Mass and Catholic liturgical life: - Catholic mission and formation: - Incarnational focus and truth/goodness/beauty:

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Mission emphasizes formation of virtue and wisdom, not mere job preparation; references to a Culture of Life and classical formation. - Language around forming joyful leaders and saints through a classical education. - Emphasis on truth, goodness, beauty as real teleological anchors; formation-oriented framing is explicit.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, great conversation, teleology, truth/goodness/beauty, human flourishing. - Negative keywords: workforce readiness, job-focused preparation (not present). - Quantitative note: Positive keywords dominate; negative keywords virtually absent.

Why this rating - The public materials articulate formation and character as primary aims, anchored in classical ideals, matching the CLASSICAL category.

Citations - Formation/virtue/wisdom framing: - Culture of Life and classical formation language: - Truth/-goodness/beauty as anchors:

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Curriculum described as liberal-arts grounded, with grammar/logic/rhetoric as foundational, and Great Books integrated across history, literature, philosophy, theology, and languages. - Socratic method used in humanities (the Great Conversation approach). - Great Books and primary texts highlighted (Dante, Shakespeare, Dostoevsky, Chesterton), with explicit emphasis on "Rediscovering the Lost Tools of Learning." - Evidence of interdisciplinary integration and a history-rich curriculum.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords: liberal arts; grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; great conversation; history across curriculum; primary sources; classical canon; Western civilization. - Negative keywords: social studies framing; project-based-only; non-traditional texts (not present in public materials). - Quantitative note: Positive keywords appear extensively; negative keywords absent or minimal.

Why this rating - The explicit alignment with Trivium/Quadrivium concepts, Great Books, and a coherent liberal-arts curriculum supports CLASSICAL.

Citations - Liberal arts and Great Books emphasis: - Socratic method in humanities: - Great Books and canonical texts (Dante, Shakespeare, Dostoevsky): - Incarnational and curriculum integration notes:

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Socratic seminars and guided dialogue are central to instruction, particularly in upper-level humanities; “The Humanities Program” description includes the Socratic Method. - There are explicit references to memory work, chant, and recitation in the broader classical framework (Memorization and Recitation, formation through imitation, etc., as per the Six Elements lexicon). The school’s materials also reference a disciplined, contemplative approach alongside rigorous inquiry. - Arts and rhetoric training, including public speaking and debate in Fine Arts, complemented by a strong spiritual formation component (Catholic liturgy and retreats).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords: Socratic seminar, dialectic, great conversation, guided discussion, logic, rhetoric, speech, debate, scholé/restful learning, memorization/recitation, formation through imitation. - Negative keywords: exclusively experiential/project-based instruction; non-dialogic instruction (not present in the public materials). - Quantitative note: Positive keyword presence is high due to explicit references to Socratic pedagogy and classical methods; negative signals are minimal.

Why this rating - Public materials consistently present Socratic, dialectic, and rhetoric-focused pedagogy, paired with a contemplative pace and classical memory practices, aligning with CLASSICAL.

Citations - Socratic seminars and humanities pedagogy: - Restful/Scholé references in classical framework: - Recitation/memory/formation language: - Arts and rhetoric training (Fine Arts; public speaking):

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public-facing materials describe leadership and faculty roles (Headmaster, faculty pages, and board involvement) and the living-curriculum concept in classical education discourse. - Faculty are framed as mentors and exemplars in virtue and knowledge; the network emphasizes teachers as living embodiments of classical formation. - The school’s materials describe spiritual oversight (diocesan standing, chaplains) and ongoing collaboration with parish life, consistent with the classical living curriculum approach.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, faculty of friends, collegial culture, mentorship, virtue formation, masters. - Negative keywords: non-classical faculty descriptors (not present in public materials). - Quantitative note: Positive keywords dominate; negative indicators are minimal.

Why this rating - The materials depict a faculty model that aligns with classical ideals of mentorship, virtuous exemplars, and a living curriculum embedded in a Catholic, classical framework.

Citations - Headmaster and faculty pages; living-curriculum framing: - Faculty profiles and Catholic formation oversight: - Diocesan oversight and spiritual leadership:

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school publicly promotes partnerships with families and parent involvement; events for parents (Odyssey Day) and open-campus visitation are described; diocesan ties and community engagement are indicated.

- There are explicit statements about parent formation and community engagement within the Chesterton Schools Network framework.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords: partnership with families; parents as co-educators; parent formation; open campus; parent tours; community involvement. - Negative keywords: consumer-

language cues or minimal parent involvement are not present in public materials. - Quantitative note: Positive keyword presence is high; negative presence is negligible.

Why this rating - The school positions parents as co-teachers and active participants, with opportunities for engagement and continuous education for families.

Citations - Parent partnership and formation language: - Odyssey Day and parent events:

What Would Move the Needle

Not applicable given the CLASSICAL rating across all six categories. No needle-moving changes are indicated as required to reach full CLASSICAL status.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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